

Complex Embodiments in *A Body Undone*

How does one “understand a body so fundamentally transformed?” This question guides Christina Crosby’s memoir, *A Body Undone*, as she confronts the gap between the body she previously had and the body she has now, as well as the interdependencies that shape her existence, after a biking accident that left her partially paralyzed and living with chronic pain. Her complex experience of her new embodiment is heavily shaped by the pain she experiences, and through rendering her pain into text, she attempts to construct and understand her new embodiment. She constructs her pain through dualities: the figurative sensory experience contrasts the factual biomedical experience, and pain can be felt, generated, and imposed both externally or internally in her descriptions. Crosby’s focus on the sensory, lived expression of the body values experience over fact in constructing embodied knowledge, and the reliance on the external forms of pain creates a distance that reveals the tension in reconstruction for the reconstructee, as well as an admirable commitment to authenticity in embodiment. Ultimately, these contrasting forms are allowed to coexist in an account that embraces the many complexities of embodied experience.

Crosby’s contrast between figurative and literal descriptions of her pain illustrates the tension between explicit, biomedical information and embodied knowledge in understanding one’s own embodiment. Ultimately, this language demonstrates how feeling supersedes the biomedical in conveying understanding of one’s state of being. This contrast is most apparent through the dominant metaphor of electricity: Crosby describes her pain as “currents running through [her] body,” creating an experience-based embodiment of her pain through this metaphor (See addendum for passage being analyzed). Simultaneously, she acknowledges that the current and electricity are not simply imagery, they function as a biologically accurate description of the state of her pain, as “the signal that passes biochemically from one neuron to another, lighting up neural networks, is, in fact, electrical.” Though her experience of pain and

the technical biological understanding converge, there is a gulf in understanding her condition when that embodied experience is available as opposed to when she is supplied with only the biomedical, factual account. She remarks that initially, her knowledge of her injury was limited—she “‘knew,’ of course, from bedside conversations with [her] physicians and with [her partner] all that was known about the injury,” yet the scare quotes demonstrate a deficient kind of knowledge that comes from relying solely on explicit knowledge. However, she identifies a specific point at which she “finally grasped the extent of my paralysis,” when she “awoke at night on fire,” demonstrating the role of feelings and experience in allowing her deeper understanding of her body post-injury.

This tension between the two types of knowledge is omnipresent in this book, as medical terminology and biomedicine injects norms into her experience in ways that can be deleterious, both in terms of her understanding of her embodiment and her physical health outcomes. Consider, for example, the line “what a horror that the drugs I was being given didn’t make it stop.” This line demonstrates both a physical limitation of the biomedical community, as well as the “horror” imposed on her psyche and the mind-body under flux during her transformed embodiment. The horror is increased by the experience of chronic pain and being given drugs that cannot return her to her previous state of embodiment. To understand her new embodiment, she often must cast off these inauthentic intrusions of biomedicine, turning to her sensational experience to understand her post-injury embodiment. Yet, there is room in her story for both forms of knowledge to interact—her knowledge of axons, ions, and electric currents in the body provides the foundation for a grounded description of her embodied experience. The factual, biomedical knowledge finds its utility in its ability to be transmuted into descriptive language, saving her from a form of hermeneutic injustice in which she would not have the words to express these sensations. Both are important, yet for Crosby to ultimately gain a new understanding of her body, she must rely on the intuitive feeling and experience, not

the external, fact-based knowledge of the biomedical, which demonstrates the strength of this way of knowing for chronic pain.

However, it is still not enough to simply feel the pain for her to understand it. This experience of pain is inherently more complex than a simple, digital “yes” or “no,” presence or absence. Crosby explores the complex interplay between externalities and internalities of pain, in which external pain originates or exists both on top of the body, whereas internal pain comes from deeper inside the body and originates within it, respectively. In relying more on the externalities in her memoir, she reflects the horror of the experience and the betrayal of her body, demonstrating the ongoing nature of constructing one’s embodiment. These externalities are invoked when she describes pain as something which “could outline my body by thickly fizzing my skin,” where the words “outline” and “skin” invoke an idea of pain as existing on top of the most external part of the body, in this case, building up a thicker metaphorical layer on top of her by “fizzing” the skin. Moreover, the unspoken word “pain” is the subject of that sentence, and the object on which it acts is “my skin,” implying a separation between pain and body in which pain is the actor and the body endures the experience.

Similarly, the second use of the word “outline” in the phrase, “my skeleton was burning, every bone outlined in red,” further cements the idea of pain as a sort of coating, or one that traces the body. This quote focuses on the outline of the bones instead of the skin, which are physically deeper and thus imply a spatial experience of pain that is more internal, yet this reference is still relatively muted compared to traditional internalities of pain. Indeed, comparing this phrase with another commonly used phrase for feeling and pain of “I felt it in” or “I felt it within my bones,” is illuminating, as Crosby’s phrase subverts this cliché. This is both a testament to her literary merit and an intriguing indication of the difference between her pain as an external outline and the deeper pain that is invoked. Though depth is typically synonymous with the magnitude or extent of the feeling, her usage subverts this traditional understanding, showing how she focuses on developing an authentic understanding of her new embodied

experience. Moreover, the unused cliché has a subject-object construction that is the opposite of Crosby's writing: in the cliché, the subject is "I" and the object is the pain in the body, implying that Crosby understands her pain differently and with a different locus of control than those who do not experience chronic pain. This distant experience is situated within externalities, as opposed to the more common internal description of pain.

While Crosby does occasionally invoke the internal experience of pain, she rarely does so without alluding to the externalities of pain, contributing to the complexity of the embodiment that she must integrate with her new sense of her body. She describes how sometimes, the pain would "more deeply penetrate my extremities," situating her pain as internal because the word "penetrate" directly opposes the external. However, the pain itself has an implied directionality that gestures back to externality: the fact that it is penetrating signifies that it started on the outside and is working its way within. A similar idea is stated when she claims the electricity feels as if it was "let loose" on her, crafting a sentence where the pain operates as the subject in this sentence and the body operates as the object, the body is subjected to the pain's electric rage. The phrase "let loose" is also repeated in a line stating "ferocious buzzing was let loose on me by scrambled nerves," which recreates a similar subject-object structure, in which the main difference is that the subject is shifted from the pain to the nerves creating the pain-- though the nerves are within the body, they are still treated as a distinct entity from the object of "me," so this minor shift ultimately retains a similar meaning in drawing out the externalities of pain.

Indeed, Crosby's most explicit construction of internal pain comes during her description of the biology of the nervous system, in which she gives a brief acknowledgement that her "central nervous system was sending out solar flares," where the "central nervous system" is an object that is within, and the word "out" reverses the directionality presented earlier-- in this case, the pain starts within and moves outwards, creating a true internal source for her descriptions of this pain. Yet the fact that the internality of pain is rare in this autobiography is revealing: relying too heavily on the internalities would be to recognize the betrayal of the

subject-body, which is inflicting pain on itself. Instead of condemning her body by catering to the internalities, externalities create a more nuanced understanding of the body, in which there is a distance between the body and the pain. This creates a compelling statement about implied separation between the self (where “I” or “me” as the self, or the subject of these grammatical constructions) and the pain and nerves that act upon it. Throughout the book, Crosby is very careful in her terminology, delineating the bodymind, mind, body, and self; This proves to be a necessary strategy for relearning a sense of all of these categories. Her carefullness ultimately adds to the complexity of the embodiment of pain by subtly pointing out the differences between self and embodiment.

Moreover, Crosby’s account is generally focused on redefining a new embodiment, yet there is a resistance to the traditional journey of crafting a new embodiment which is reflected by the distance created in this subject-object dynamic. She fights hard in the continual phenomenological study of herself, but she denies the existence of straightforward endings to her journey (she is wary of the existence of that archetypical journey in the first place). She carefully carves out meaning in this ongoing process, and this distance shows she is willing to push back against this new state of her body while still finding reasons to continue to live and move on in her life, a form of acceptance which is authentic to her own embodiment.

Through an exploration of the dualities of pain, Crosby is able to use her memoir to construct an embodiment for herself that cannot be simply categorized. Her reliance on the sensory experience over biomedical fact and her emphasis on externalities over internalities reveal a careful negotiation as she understands her transformed body, and simultaneously allows herself room to grieve the previous body she has lost. Ultimately, her reconstruction of embodiment is not triumphant, but is an ongoing, authentic engagement which supersedes the superficial success story by honoring the reality of an embodied experience with liveable pain while carving out her life within her new body.

ADDENDUM:

“More dreadful than the gas or the gel, even more terrible than the terrible thirst, were the painful currents running through my body. I’d never felt anything remotely like it. My drugged sleep yielded up a vivid nightmare— my skeleton was burning, every bone outlined in red. Pain felt like electricity somehow let loose on me, a statement that is both figurative and not, because the signal that passes biochemically from one neuron to another, lighting up neural networks, is, in fact, electrical— the passage of ions down the axon of a neuron and across the synapse to another neuron, continually, instantly accomplished trillions of times in complex networks all through your body. Trillions. My central nervous system was sending out solar flares. Perhaps the most terrible night came weeks into my stay at the Hospital for Special Care, when I finally grasped the extent of my paralysis. I awoke at night on fire, my skin crisping from the soles of my feet, up my legs and back, tight around my abdomen right up to just under my rib cage, and down my arms onto my hands. I was burning the way you burn when shocked with static electricity, but the shock was infinitely multiplied and running thickly, continuously under my skin. This ferocious buzzing was let loose on me by scrambled nerves that will never ever fully recover, neurological pain that could outline my body by thickly fizzing my skin, as it did that night, or more deeply penetrate my extremities, as was sometimes the case. What a horror, to finally and viscerally understand how profoundly I was hurt! I “knew,” of course, from bedside conversations with my physicians and with Janet all that was known about the injury I had sustained. My mind was intact, but how could I understand a body so fundamentally transformed? I had no real idea until then of the scope of my injury, how far up on my body it came. And what a horror that the drugs I was being given didn’t make it stop.”

Crosby, Christina. *A Body, Undone: Living On After Great Pain*. New York University Press, 2016, pg 26-27.